

Guyana Skies

A sketch of a potential script

By Frank Kirwan

Act One

The show starts with the main character, provisionally named Patrick, who, as an old man now settled in London, drifts back, as he talks with his children about memories of his own childhood and early adulthood in Georgetown, Guyana. The chorus sung (with spoken words) “Guyana Skies” expresses his memories as he drifts into sleep.

Song 1 — Guyana Skies

We go back to Patrick’s childhood in Georgetown where a peaceful and friendly neighbourhood is interrupted by a major crime, a naughty boy (Patrick) stealing coconuts from the neighbour’s tree. Hence the song “Coconut Water”, sung by the neighbour, Patrick’s father and Patrick.

Song 2 — Coconut Water

Patrick grows up and has a great time in Georgetown, where, as Jazzy P, he plays his trumpet in a local band. He meets a girl called Shirley who he becomes attached to after getting a date with her after a dance after a bet with friends. She gets wind of the bet, but he wins her over with his song “Shirley”.

Song 3 — Shirley

Shirley joins Patrick’s band and they get on well together, eventually getting engaged, after much humorous discussion and the song “Tell me once”.

Song 4 — Tell me once

Meanwhile British Guyana, and Georgetown in particular, is gearing up for independence. Shirley sings the song “Independence”, which reflects the excitement and anticipation of a nation.

Song 5 — Independence

Post independence, with things not going so smoothly with him or his music, Patrick becomes restless. He decides to move to London where he hopes to get a good job and continue to work at nights as a trumpeter. He tells Shirley, and his friends. Carried away, he launches into the frenetic “Flying into London”.

Song 6 — Flying into London

A surfeit of rum finds him ill the next day. Shirley comes round to “soothe his fevered brow”, but drops the bombshell that for now she can’t go to London because of visa problems. Patrick has already made unbreakable arrangements, so Act One ends with the disappointing news that they will be on different sides of the world.

Act Two

Patrick has arrived in London and all is not what he expected. The “good job” he looked for doesn’t exist and he has to work in a factory for low wages, accommodation is a major problem and finding work with his trumpet proves impossible. With the cold weather and a people he doesn’t understand, he goes from his usual positivity and energy to an all-time low. Solitary, in his lodgings, he sings “What happened to my dream?”

Song 1 — What happened to my dream?

Patrick encounters racism and scorn and meets some unsavoury characters in a pub who provoke him by talking about the sort of work he is only fit for.

Song 2 — Make ’em work

After the song Patrick is involved in a fight with one of the racists. He is blamed for it and arrested. All looks bleak for him, as he’s charged and goes home with a record. An acquaintance from home comes round and tries to persuade him to make money via crime, as he’s already got a record. The dialogue continues in the next song.

Song 3 — Wrong time, wrong place

Patrick is about to give in to the temptation, as he sees no other way out, when, out of the blue, Shirley reappears, gives him a good dressing down and tells him they’re going to use her money to set up a hairdressing shop in Peckham. She persuades him to look forward to a life of hard work, but success in a new country.

Song 4 — Everyone has a hope

Patrick is now older, though not yet old, he has children and is very settled, and back to his old self. We meet him in the same pub where he had the fight and now he enjoys good natured banter with the locals about London weather and how much better Georgetown is than Peckham. He’s never returned to Georgetown as he says he wants to move forward in his life, not backwards, but he’s beginning to waver.

Song 5 — Peckham Calypso

Patrick awakes from his sleep to be surrounded by his family, who’ve got him tickets for a month’s stay back in Georgetown. Much rejoicing, and a reprise of the title song.

Song 6 — Guyana Skies